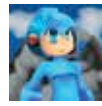


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Material Design Lite: Materialise your Web Pages

There's a new CSS framework for Material Design in town and this time it's by Google itself.

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CSS frameworks implementing Material Design have been cropping up regularly ever since it was first announced. Some come as extensions to existing CSS frameworks, like the many plugins available for Bootstrap, and others are fully featured frameworks based on material design, for example Materialize CSS.

Finally, we have an official Google-developed CSS framework for material design called Material Design Lite – why



'lite' find out soon! With this, Google aims to plug in any design gaps left in the specification; gaps that other frameworks have had to fill in without Google's guidance and not always to their satisfaction.

What is Material Design?

Material Design is Google's new design language that forms the basis of their Android 5.0 version and most of their current mobile applications.

If you've used Google's new email application Inbox – you have already seen Material Design in action. Most popular Android applications today have adapted their UIs to use this new design language.

Google unhelpfully describes the goal of Material Design as:

'Create a visual language that synthesizes classic principles of good design with the innovation and possibility of technology and science.'

'Develop a single underlying system that allows for a unified experience across platforms and device sizes. Mobile precepts are fundamental, but touch, voice, mouse, and keyboard are all first-class input methods.'

Material Design, similar to Microsoft's 'Modern UI' style focuses on a clean visual with minimal chrome. Google's design specification goes into details about how visual elements should be layered and presented, what to do, what not to do, all complete with images and videos.

How it Relates to Polymer

Polymer is another web framework by Google that implements the Material Design as part of its Paper elements component set. To use these elements though you had to make a somewhat large commitment to using the web components model that Polymer uses.

Polymer is an entire web framework designed for building applications, and as such it's not easy to adopt its Material Design without needing to rewrite parts of an existing application. Additionally,

if what you wanted to apply the Material Design to your blog, or website, Polymer was a bit too heavy for something that simple where you don't need an entire application framework.

That is where the 'Lite' comes in. Material Design Lite (MDL) doesn't need you to use web components, or Polymer and doesn't prescribe any other framework either. All you need to do is include a CSS file for MDL, a CSS file for the font, and a single JavaScript file, and you are set. It will work with your current application framework, or even without a framework at all if you have a blog or plain site rather than an app. MDL can still be used in conjunction with Polymer though.

Using MDL with your Website

Using MDL is similar to using something like Bootstrap. You simply include the CSS and JavaScript code for the framework and then use the appropriate CSS classes to get visual styling that you want.

There is also an online customisation tool available for MDL that allows you to select a primary and accent colour for your theme. Merely select the two colours from a wheel available on their customisation page, and you will get the MDL CSS file for that theme.

While MDL covers some of the same ground as Bootstrap, it is certainly not a complete replacement. It does not have as broad a feature-set, rather it focuses on basic styling for web pages and components. For one, MDL does not include any form of grid for layout. You will need